have to correctly understand the present, it is important to put the past in perspective," she adds. The genre has caught on too, albeit not all have the stellar result that *The Kashmir Files* did at the box office by amassing Rs 246 crore domestically.

Pallavi admits that their brand of cinema has meant them being flagged as 'propaganda filmmakers', but the duo couldn't care less about the label. "As long as I know we are honest with our messaging, my conscience is clear," she says. "I hope [through *The Bengal Files*] the message reaches the people—how India is being pulled apart by divisive politics."

The *Files* trilogy, says Pallavi, draws inspiration from the "three pillars of the Ashok Chakra, India's national emblem: right to truth, justice and life". While *Tashkent* attempted to uncover the mystery behind the death of Prime Minister Lal Bahadur Shastri and *Kashmir* documented the reign of terror in the Valley triggering the exodus of Kashmiri Pandits, *Bengal*, going by the trailer, touches on a range of topics, including illegal immigrants and the exodus of Hindus. At least one character declares: "*Kya hum aazaad hain* (Are we truly free)?"

For the couple, the partition of Bengal was not explored enough in mainstream Hindi cinema. The biggest of the *Files* trilogy thus far in terms of budget and scale, the *Bengal* edition is also the longest, oscillating between pre-partition Bengal going back to the Direct Action Day and its aftermath to the present with events set in Murshidabad. Tight-lipped about her own character, Pallavi says, "Either they are going to like me or hate me. Vivek keeps throwing curveballs my way. It's frightening yet challenging." ■

—Suhani Singh

mon's films fascinated me," he says. "I realised that you could make films without a budget, expensive equipment or even other people."

The festival is focused on "archival experimental filmmaking practices", says Jahan, where the films treat personal or official archives "as a living, breathing, dynamic, and restless entity susceptible to revision, interruption and reanimation, as opposed to a static repository of the past". To that effect, *The Dithering Veil* was shot for over two years on a cheap camcorder and makes use of several in-camera and editing techniques, such as makeshift lenses, superimpositions and extremes of focus and zooming.

Welsh filmmaker Scott Barley, highly regarded in the experimental film scene, is also part of the official selection. Barley is optimistic about the future of experimental film in India and the larger Global South. "The advent of digital and the democratisation of equipment have made it possible for anybody to make a film," he says. "You don't need money to make a film. Money is a very weak currency relative to other things. Time, resilience, passion, limitation, intuition, vision—these are the currencies that make a work truly great." ■

—Devarsi Ghosh

HISTORY ▼

Delhi in Focus

DAG's *The City as a Museum* debuts in Delhi, tracing the capital's layered histories through exhibitions, walks and performances

After four successful editions in Kolkata and an outing in Mumbai earlier this year, DAG's flagship art and heritage festival *The City as a Museum* makes its debut in Delhi. The showcase, spanning exhibitions, walks, performances and dialogues from September 6–21, returns to the city where DAG started nearly 30 years ago. "Delhi felt like a natural progression," says Ashish Anand, CEO and MD, DAG.

Grover's trilogy 'The Fifth Circle', which reimagines the Mandi House area through an audio walk, performance and panel discussion. A pop-up exhibition, *Artists in Residence*, at Garhi Studios will reflect on Delhi's artist colonies and their role in modernist experimentation.



A preparatory oil sketch of 'State Entry into Delhi of Lord and Lady Curzon (Delhi Durbar, 1903)' by Roderick MacKenzie

"It's where our story began, and its layered history—from Sultanate and Mughal eras to colonial rule and independent India—offers a unique lens on the ties between art, culture and nation."

The edition foregrounds Delhi's unique cultural ecosystem, highlighting its role in shaping modern Indian art not only through state-led initiatives but also through artist-driven neighbourhoods. Among the highlights is historian Rudrangshu Mukherjee's revisiting of Delhi in the aftermath of 1857 through rare photographs and theatre-maker Amitesh

At the festival's heart lies *Sair-e-Dilli: Chronicles of Change*, an exhibition curated by historian Swapna Liddle at Bikaner House (till September 15). Featuring paintings, prints, photographs, maps and plans, it captures Delhi's built forms across eras.

Looking ahead, Anand says DAG plans to take *The City as a Museum* to more cities, including Chennai, Baroda and Jaipur. "We have only begun to scratch the surface of our collection," he notes. "Our hope is to widen public access and place it in dialogue with other archives and repositories." ■

—Geetika Sachdev